



America boasts three excellent players, all age 26 — No. 10 Taylor Fritz, No. 14 Tommy Paul, and No. 15 Frances Tiafoe — but none is likely to win a major or an Olympic gold medal.

With this context in mind, 6'4", 74th-ranked Alex Michelsen, the youngest player ranked in the top 100, has emerged as an intriguing talent. A year ago, the skinny 19-year-old from California wasn't even contemplating a pro career when he was ranked a lowly 466. Getting a tennis scholarship at a Division I college was still the family goal.

His father Erik, a three-time All-American at the University of Redlands (Calif.), and his mother Sondra, a standout at San Diego State, gave Michelsen the benefits of nature and nurture.

"They taught me from an early age [3 years old] how to play tennis," he recalled in a *Tennis Channel* video

titled — 'Is Alex Michelsen the next big American star?'

"Especially my mom. I went out every single day to hit tennis balls with her," he said. "She's my hero. She's the biggest influence in my life."

When Michelsen was 16, he began training rigorously with the USTA's Tier 1 Performance squad of promising juniors. Jay Leavitt, who with Erik Diaz coached Michelsen, said, "He's a great competitor. He has a will to win that I haven't seen from many kids his age. When he was 16, 17, 18, he started surpassing the others." Leavitt and Diaz strengthened his backhand volley (which had been two-handed) and his forehand.

The summer of 2023 marked the turning point of his young career. At a Challenger event in Chicago, Michelsen, then ranked No. 190, upset former US Open finalist Kei Nishikori. Jubilant, he phoned his parents and asked, "What do you

Big stage nerves: Alex Michelsen (L) faced Alexander Zverev in the third round of the Australian Open. The American put up a tough fight in the second set tie-break but eventually lost in three sets. GETTY IMAGES

guys think about going pro?" His father, a real estate attorney, fired back, "Yeah, you're going to go pro, but it's going to be in real estate." In early August, Michelsen was still committed to enrolling at the University of Georgia.

He sealed the deal, though, when he defeated Maxime Cressy, James Duckworth, Mackenzie McDonald, and former top-tenner John Isner to reach the final at Newport. "Believe you me," said his father, "with me being an attorney and my wife being a teacher, we put up a lot of resistance." His mother said, "But with his recent results, it was just hard to say no. And he really wanted